Bibliographic Essay

Recent research on Myanmar suffers from the closed political environment in the country. Travel to the region for researchers has been problematic for several decades. Primary accounts of life in modern Myanmar are written covertly, and either smuggled out or written under pseudonyms. Most research on the country has come from secondary sources from journalists, and Western academics.

Many of the early contributions to postindependence Burma are general compilations on Southeast Asia generally. John Cady's *Postwar Southeast Asia*, D.G.E. Hall's *A History of South East Asia*, and David Steinberg's *In Search of Southeast Asia* are comparative works on the region that included significant contributions on the early postindependence period. Cady's early works on Burma including *A History of Modern Burma*, set the mark for scholarship on Burmese studies.

On the postcolonial independence period Hugh Tinker's *The Union of Burma: A Study of the First Years of Independence* was the earliest account of the fledging independent Burma. Frank Trager's *Building a Welfare State in Burma, 1948–1956* discusses the failed attempt at state building following the departure of the British and the assassination of Aung San. Political scientist Robert Taylor's *The State in Burma* (1987) and the updated *The State of Myanmar* (2009) are exhaustive overviews that chronicle the evolution and development of the modern Burmese state. Thant Myint-U's *The Making of Modern Burma* written by U Thant's grandson is a readable resource that mixes both primary and secondary accounts.

The defining scholarship on the developments in modern Burmese comes from Georgetown University political scientist David Steinberg. *Burma: The State of Myanmar* and *Turmoil in Burma: Contested Legitimacies in Myanmar* are two of the most significant scholarly works on contemporary Burma. Steinberg is able to analyze the historical development as well as the political changes within Burmese society. More recently, Michael Charney from the London School of Economics and Politics has completed a very concise and readable history of contemporary Burma. His *A History*